

Reviews and Replies on Rasmus Nielsen (1867)

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*R. Nielsen: Om den gode Vilje som Magt i
Videnskaben*

[85]

[On the Good Will as a Power in Science]

(1867)

In reply to Bishop Martensen's treatise *Om Tro og Viden*, Professor Nielsen has published, under the imprint of the *Gyldendal Bookshop*, *Om den gode Vilje som Magt i Videnskaben*, a broad and heavy-handed, a scornful and biting little book, written with an overflowing zest for producing and full of good sallies. Its merriment, however, has in places a character more Dutch than Danish.

That the title is ironic, since the book sets out to show that in science the good will counts for nothing, is a piece of information that needs to be given to those who still remember that there was a time when Professor Nielsen himself made the theologized conscience the starting point of true science, and when it was proclaimed from the Professor's own lips that, e.g., the freethinker's biblical criticism, though *impersonally true*, was without value, because it had its ground in a *personal untruth*. It is all the more necessary to stress this, since fossil remains of this view still occur to this very day in the productions turned out by Professor Nielsen's present followers, so that these may see that they must make some haste if they mean to keep up, and not, like their predecessors, be left astern and lost along the way.

The book can be seen from two sides: it means to tear down and it means to build up. It means to *tear down* theology. What is theology? It is a discipline that stands [86] in the same relation to philosophy as alchemy to scientific chemistry and astrology to astronomy. It has outlived its kindred spirits; it is one of the many relics of the Middle Ages that are slowly crumbling away in modern society. A fight against this dying thing has lost all interest; it is a spectacle unworthy of the educated man, the working man, the striving man, from which he would far rather turn his eyes away. How, then, can Professor Nielsen go on regarding theology as a fit object for an attack with sharp weapons? Who attacks a defenseless old woman who can scarcely hold herself upright on her crutches? Who leaps with drawn blade aboard a sinking hulk that is slowly going to the bottom with every man and mouse aboard?

I know of no other answer than this: whom one loves, one chastens. Professor Nielsen answers Bishop Martensen as he answered Pastor Zeuthen; he has always had a

little to spare — at least a little printer's ink to spare — for the ordained, say what he will. The only thing that might cause surprise is that Professor Nielsen, in his zeal as an educator, has forgotten the fine old schoolmaster's rule: If I were not angry, you should have a thrashing; for Professor Nielsen is angry, and he lays on all the same, and so he lays on wildly and now and then, out of sheer zeal, raps himself over the knuckles.

A reader who has taken in the whole impression of the critical research of the modern age cannot but regret that Professor Nielsen, under the influence of a vehemence younger than his years, has geology assign Paradise its place in the "nursery" and the botanist send its trees "to hell"; for such expressions will unpleasantly remind him of the time when science was polemical because it was not yet able to be critical, of the time when people mocked tradition and miracle instead of understanding and explaining the psychological origin and the historical development of miracle and tradition. That time, you see, is past, and it cannot be Professor Nielsen's intention to call it back. For that he has, on the one hand, far too thorough a cultivation, and on the other, far too thorough a goodwill toward this very theology from which he set out and toward which he still feels himself irresistibly drawn. This is a point one must always hold fast to, or one will feel bewildered at every moment. There are, e.g., passages in the Professor's [87] book by which one might otherwise let oneself be misled into the mistaken assumption that the Professor's last word actually coincided with the freethinker's first; so, e.g., the excellently witty piece that ends with the words: "They (the theologians) recognized that they could no longer go on talking loudly about the supernatural facts of history, since the supernatural facts were presumably not historical, and the historical ones not supernatural"; but no one must let himself be bewildered by such things. When Professor Nielsen here appeals to experience and to "sound common sense", which, as the serpent, gives theology to eat of the tree of knowledge, he does not mean it seriously; his own standpoint is not that of "sound common sense" but a quite different one, which shall now be demonstrated as we pass on to what Professor Nielsen means to *build up*.

"Sound common sense" sees, e.g., that there is exactly as much and exactly as little reason to assume demons as to assume centaurs. A scientific critic explains how belief in demons arose among the peoples of antiquity. Professor Nielsen, finally, goes about it thus: he begins by ignoring the objection of sound common sense; next he grants the critic that he is right "from the standpoint of science"; but then he himself adds to the latter's critique of knowledge a "critique of faith", which obeys laws of its own and has nothing to do with the critique of knowledge, is not crossed by it, does not collide with it either in war or in peace, because any collision is impossible, since the two critiques

each obey an absolutely different principle. The critique of knowledge has abolished demons, but at the same time explained them; the critique of faith keeps them wherever their existence “makes visible the fundamental miracle of faith”; that the whole question of demons is, for sound common sense, devoid of all interest and settled in advance does not come into consideration. How, then, do matters stand when the critique of faith comes to learn how loftily the critique of knowledge, which keeps its papers in another drawer of the brain, treats the critique of faith’s own demons? The secret is: it does not come to learn it. How so? “For the moment the critique of faith comes to learn it, it is no longer critique of faith, but critique of knowledge.” It is impossible that the river Tajo can flow into Portugal, for the very moment it flows into Portugal it is no longer called Tajo, but Tejo.

The critique of faith and the critique of knowledge, then, can as little hinder or limit each other as faith and knowledge themselves, which Professor Nielsen, calmly [88] unconcerned about all objections, continues to describe as “absolutely heterogeneous principles”. The further development of this is as follows, and most peculiar:

Consciousness is halved by relatively homogeneous factors, but not by absolutely heterogeneous ones. When a consciousness is halved in thought, it gets half a thought instead of a whole one: what is lacking is thought; if it is halved in will, it gets half a will instead of a whole one: what is lacking is will. On the other hand, one cannot in the stricter sense say that consciousness is halved by thought and will, such that half of the thought becomes will, half of the will thought [can one say this nonsense in any sense whatever?], for thought can be transformed into will, and will into thought, only in a highly figurative sense. [It is natural enough that the figurative expression — transformation — must be taken in a figurative and not in a literal sense]. If it is established, then, that faith can in no way [a moment ago it was only: not in the literal sense] be transformed into knowledge, or knowledge into faith, then it is also established that faith can as little be halved by knowledge as knowledge by faith. If a consciousness cannot be halved by friendship and mathematics, by love and chemistry, still less can it be halved by ethics and astronomy, by religion and geology.

It is a drawback that precisely what was to be proved has here been presupposed. That a true morality and a true religiosity cannot collide with a true scientific spirit goes without saying. But the question is precisely which morality and which religiosity is the true one, a positive one or a free one? The question is, e.g., whether the ancient religious representations of a small Semitic tribe, often enough at odds with itself, from the most diverse periods — representations that are at every point interwoven with, and borne up by, its whole world view, its ideas of the origin of the earth, its superstition, its countless prejudices — whether these do or do not contradict our geology and our astronomy. They

contradict them, in the same way as in countless cases they contradict our morality and our religious feeling. But if Professor Nielsen by no means succeeds in keeping the two hemispheres apart, he succeeds far less still, in the end, in uniting them. For however sharp the separation is claimed to be, a union must, after all, be conceivable: "The two absolutely heterogeneous principles meet, part, and *in a way* enter into negotiation with each other in the medium of *meaning*". Meaning — that is the saving category; on the [89] neutral ground of meaning the two absolutely heterogeneous ones negotiate with each other. The only party that could have anything against such a negotiation would be the Danish language; for it is indeed the philosophers' prerogative to teach language some sense; but the two heterogeneous ones are related, after all, as love and mathematics are; what is the name of the medium in which love and mathematics conduct their negotiations?

Professor Nielsen elucidates by an example: "What is told in the first book of Moses about Paradise, about the tree of life, the tree of knowledge, etc., is certainly told with the meaning that all of it belongs to external reality, that the tree of life and the tree of knowledge have their roots in the sensuous soil of the garden just as surely as the vine or the fig tree. But in this meaning we cannot possibly take it *at the present stage of cultural consciousness?*"

Did we read that right? Cultural consciousness? Is Professor Nielsen forgetting himself and his own assertions? What business has cultural consciousness here, pray? Is the critique of faith to be grounded on cultural consciousness, and faith nevertheless be absolutely heterogeneous with it, not to be determined and not to be limited from it? What a web of brain-spun fancy, what a muddle, out of which there is no way out! Moral: do not give cultural consciousness your little finger, or it will quickly take the whole hand.

"Those images," says Professor Nielsen, "have not outer but inner reality." That this is not new is known to everyone who knows anything of the history of theology; that it is unintelligible is found by everyone who tries to think it through. What is inner reality, if it is to be different from poetic reality? — "The legend of Paradise," says Professor Nielsen, "cannot possibly be myth, as surely as it reveals to the eye of faith, in pure, clear strokes, one of the deepest mysteries of the will." Does the myth of Prometheus perhaps not do the same? And is this a distinguishing mark? When the legend is here denied outward reality, it is a matter of indifference whether it is called myth or not. That Paradise has a poetic reality which the "Jura" and "graywacke" do not have goes without saying and is denied by no one.

To the psychological union in the clime of *meaning* there now corresponds the essential (ontological) one in that of *mystery*. The development of this point is given in a language that regrettably recalls the most unintelligible dialect of the Hegelian age.

Faith and knowledge can be united only in an absolute mystery. The absolute mystery is [90] at once exclusive boundary and negative middle. As exclusive boundary the mystery sets a separation between faith and knowledge as between two regions. When the believer looks toward the center of faith, and the knower toward the center of knowledge, what is true in faith becomes untrue in knowledge, and vice versa. As negative middle, on the other hand, the mystery unites the separated extremes and shows itself as the medium of passage between the regions. When the believer and the knower both at the same time direct their gaze toward the mystery, the strife is settled and the extremes are reconciled. Seen from the standpoint of knowledge, the miracle is now possible [yes, what can a punctilious drill not achieve, where one looks to the right and to the left at the same time!]. For while it is indeed impossible that a breach should ever occur in the eternal laws of nature, which are identical with the necessity of reason, yet with the immutability of the laws — when the intermediate determinations hidden in the mystery are understood — the manifestation of the power of will, of wisdom and of love, in which the believer sees (!) the miracle, can very well be thought to subsist. Seen from the standpoint of faith, the necessity of reason, with the immutable laws of nature, can be united with the presupposition of the miracle. For while it is indeed impossible that necessity should be able to hamper freedom, and the laws of nature limit God's will, yet, when the intermediate determinations hidden in the mystery are understood, it can indeed be thought that the laws of nature, far from being broken, are on the contrary fulfilled in the very highest sense every time a divine act of will is accomplished.

This was good theology in the old days. Philosophical hints of something of the sort are found, e.g., in the German clergyman Bockshammer, who is cited by J. L. Heiberg in *Prosaiske Skrifter* I, 110. He concludes with a flowing torrent of words that contains the self-same assertion. For more than an unproved and unprovable assertion this is not, after all. Let us choose a miracle from the New Testament, e.g., the scorching of the fig tree by the divine word of power that punishes it for not bearing fruit. One need not, after all, be a thinker to see that a miracle like this — whose psychological origin, incidentally, seems to be the misunderstanding of a parable as though it were historical reality — that such a miracle cannot be brought into agreement with the laws of nature either in a plain and simple sense or in any higher or “very highest” sense. That Most Highest Sense will only waste its strength here.

The duel between Bishop Martensen and Professor Nielsen, these two so practiced and accomplished champions, makes — be it said with sincere regret — the same impression as a practice bout between two equally poor fencers: neither of them can use his cutlass;

[91] neither of them parries the opponent's blows; but for both of them the only point is who can deal the other the quickest and heaviest blows. They strike like the old Norse berserkers, with their shields on their backs, and one is given no occasion to delight in great art or dexterity on either side. But if there is not much art here, there is all the more politics.

It was good politics on the part of His Right Reverence, Bishop Martensen, to leave Professor Nielsen's attack on his Dogmatics unanswered; for dogmatics fare nowadays like other fortresses that a hundred years ago seemed all but impregnable: they can no longer be defended; their ramparts are going downhill, their moats are gutters, and if the fortress will not surrender its keys, it does not matter, since there are no gates.

But just as surely it was good politics on the part of the philosophical champion to take the offensive and answer Bishop Martensen's polite "Good day" with a terrible "Axe-handle". Professor Nielsen's main guard is no good for defense. Professor Nielsen does have one man on guard, but he weeps — with the one eye and laughs with the other; his right hand knows not what his left is doing. He advances on two heterogeneous legs, a leg of flesh and a leg of wood, on two absolutely split legs, cleft like one of Uffe's Saxons. His head is a Janus head: with the one mouth he proclaims the higher fulfillment of the law of nature through the miracle; with his other throat he gives the honor to cultural consciousness and sings a well-meant hymn of praise to David Strauss. This last is perhaps the oddest among many odd features of this feud. The congregation is admonished by Professor Nielsen, far from taking offense at Strauss's audacity, to appreciate the help that this man, by his "consistent and resolute" procedure, has directly rendered faith, in that he has founded the critique of knowledge to which Professor Nielsen, by his projected critique of faith, means to supply the necessary counterpart. Bishop Martensen must take a scolding for his orthodox condemnation of Strauss. "If Strauss is to be excommunicated, then there are many who must be excommunicated" [yes, why not, that is after all a good Christian doctrine!]; "if Strauss is an Antichrist, then there are many Antichrists in the camp" [yes, what orthodox man would ever doubt it!] The Janus head turns to both sides; it stands like Don Juan between the peasant girls [92] and has fair words for both parties. The Grundtvigians get their share of them. *Dansk Kirketidende* receives public praise; Mr. N. Lindberg is commended — for what, would you think? — for *logical-categorical certainty*.

The Fool says in *Aladdin*: "I am not fooling, it stands, upon my faith, in the letter."

If anyone will take the trouble to look up the article in question, he will, it is said, be able to find in its notes interesting samples of the certainty that Professor Nielsen

singles out for praise, and so be able to convince himself with his own eyes, not of the way in which a church paper takes part in a scientific polemic, for who looks for science in church papers, but of what, in Denmark, a philosopher can praise. Professor Nielsen does not forget his Pappenheimers; his Pappenheimers will not forget him either.

[93]

*Gb. (Rudolf Schmidt):**R. Nielsens Filosofi og den Grundtvigske Anskuelse.*

[R. Nielsen's Philosophy and the Grundtvigian View]

(1867).

[94]

Under the signature *Gb.* an author who stands equally close to Grundtvig and to Nielsen has published a book of 124 pages, entitled *R. Nielsens Filosofi og den Grundtvigske Anskuelse*, a book whose form bears witness to much stylistic maturity and cultivation. Its standpoint is this: to side with Nielsen unconditionally, both where he attacks and where he is the object of attack; to assert the genuineness of Grundtvig's genius and the importance of his person and his doctrine, while at the same time critically setting apart some of the great deal that is loose and repellent and bound up with Grundtvig's whole activity; and finally, at the end, as well as it can be done, to make Nielsen and Grundtvig rhyme. The worth of the book's contents differs greatly from one part to another. It can be stated most briefly and pithily thus: the larger part, the section on Grundtvig, which is written with a respectable striving for impartiality and rests on an uncommonly wide reading in Danish literature, contains much that is true and to the point; but the two short sections on Nielsen, which begin and end the book, are downright wretched. They are not merely empty of thought but written in an impertinent and indecent manner. For it is impertinence to meddle in a serious dispute in order to deliver, with lofty condescension, one's humble opinion as though it were a verdict of the Supreme Court, when one is unable to furnish a single contribution to the dispute or to refute a single one of the arguments one brushes aside, and contents oneself instead with the empty phrase that the attackers have shown themselves to be "without the power of appropriation in the face of the new."

Everything that has so far been brought forward against the new doctrine is disposed of with the talk that, if one acknowledges Nielsen's uncommon gifts, one cannot possibly credit him with such errors and contradictions as are laid at his door. A greater perversity than the one underlying this answer, repeated often enough, cannot be conceived. Suppose a man is to go through a difficult set of accounts. This examination is regarded as a formality! for those around him hold it as an article of faith that these accounts must be correct; so they were always found by the earlier auditors, and if any of these raised difficulties, the matter was hushed up. The man would come into conflict with his own

trust in the authorities and fall out with all respectable people if he did not arrive at the given total; and so, happily, he does make it tally. Unfortunately, someone now discovers that this happy outcome is owed to the circumstance that at one place in the accounts 2 and 2 have by mistake been added up to 5. He points this out, and receives, one after the other, four answers: *a)* This objection rests on a misunderstanding. *b)* You must surely be able to tell yourself that it is impossible that a master of figures like this one *could* make such a mistake. *c)* What you say is abominable and outrageous; it undermines all confidence in the established order and the whole childlike trust in the authorities without which everything falls apart. *d)* What a threadbare and hackneyed objection! Truly a most novel and remarkable discovery, that 2 and 2 make 4!

a) The objections rest on misunderstanding. The answer is simple. How long do you think people will put up with this evasion? If we misunderstand, then open your mouths and speak plainly, so that one can understand you, instead of talking as if you had porridge in your mouths! It has come to this: it has now become the fashion in philosophy, as it has long been in politics, that the highest art of every pronouncement is to conceal where one is really heading, to express oneself in riddles, to say yes and no like a diplomatic dispatch or a speech by Napoleon III.

b) Can it be that Professor Nielsen does not know that 2 and 2 make 4?

That does not concern us and is a matter of complete indifference to us; but we point to the fact that here, on this particular point, he has let five pass for even. Can anything [95] more ridiculous be conceived than that, in the face of the specific demonstration, people go on appealing to the man's abilities? Contradictions have been demonstrated point by point in Professor Nielsen's doctrine. There is no weapon against logic but logic. But we ask logically, and you answer us lyrically. It is as if the famous Bog Wife had become the Valkyrie of the whole camp. People come forward with presentations that go by leaps, with fanciful word-paintings, parables, shadow pictures, everything except proof, refutation, logic; for of these there is not even a shadow here.

c) The objections are out to take the life of the ideals (see the review of this book in *Fædrelandet*); with dry common sense they would rob faith of its ground and enthusiasm of its source. We answer: A fig for such ideals, and to Hekkenfeldt with an enthusiasm that creeps into hiding in the bolt-hole of *existence* when science challenges it to come out into the sunlight of the spirit. Keep to the facts and refute our arguments! Let those big words, the ideals, enthusiasm, which are posted up like placards and impress the mob, go, and set proof against proof. Do not boast, then, of your exact method, which is supposed to make your chain of inferences as reliable as the mathematical one, when

everything you say has a merely belletristic and in no way whatever a scientific character. The day of belletristic truths is over. Woe to him who cannot bear the naked truth; woe to him who sees the task of philosophy in pasting the fig leaf on it!

d) What is brought forward against Professor Nielsen is old. Yes, it is old that a thinker must not contradict himself; yes, the truth is old, old as everything eternal, but what a complaint to come out with! If there is anything paltry in the youth of Denmark, it is its inclination to inferences like these: "This is new, therefore true; this is new, therefore ours; this is new, therefore that around which we must throng." The novelty-mongers do not hear the call of science: "You fools! at least test this new thing first!" "No," comes the answer, "let us hurry, let us hasten to get deep into the crush and push aside anyone who goes against the current!" And does one really think that anyone will be deterred by that? Does one really think that anyone who, in questions like these, so important, so far-reaching, so agonizing, alone with himself but face to face with the spirit of science, has wrested from it a conviction as living and as powerful as the spirit itself, cares much about these currents of the age on the surface, or about those who feel safe and strong only when, in the midst of the crush where no one can move arm or leg, they are borne along without a will of their own in the wake of some admired figure? We have no claue in our theaters; are we now to get a claue in our literature?

No, it is impossible to give up the hope that the young people of Denmark, for all their indolence, will try to arrive at an independent judgment. Let them feel their way forward; let them resolve, for once, to want to see with their own eyes! Fortunately we are not, after all, intellectually bound to the soil; there are ways out for anyone who feels that in one branch of our literature we lag behind the rest of Europe. Let the young study foreign thinkers, and it would truly be strange if they did not discover that these declamations are not refutations; let them study the more recent theism, e.g., and they will see the connection between Professor Nielsen's endeavors and the European reaction against what is taken to be a one-sided pantheism; let them only acquire a horizon, a wide horizon, and they will discover how far from unique Professor Nielsen's "immortal" treatment of the problem of subjectivity is, the treatment that the pamphlet sees in connection with Old Norse mythology.

What is at work here in leading many astray is the following reasoning: When everyone must concede that the religious problems have been treated in our own literature (first and last by Kierkegaard) with a range and a depth hardly matched, perhaps, in any European world of books, how can anyone believe that in any other we might find greater clarity about these questions than here at home! This reasoning is very seductive,

but for all its apparent force it is quite hollow. For it is by no means always the case that the most violent crisis brings about the best and truest result. No one can deny that, set beside the French Revolution of 1789 and the French revolutions that followed it, those gigantic exertions to win freedom by fighting for it, our revolution of 1848 — the long procession of respectable men who strolled arm in arm to Christiansborg — though not lacking dignity in itself, is pitiful, meek, and of no account. And yet — where is there more freedom now, in France or here? But in the religio-philosophical sphere the relation is reversed. How slight France's religious crises in this century are beside ours! And yet — where is there more truth, in French religio-philosophical criticism or [97] in our own productions in a similar direction? Anyone who has studied French literature even to some extent will hardly doubt to whom in this field he must hand the palm. For Kierkegaard is indeed — and there can be no question here of anyone but him — an immense spirit, one of those who are born scarcely once in a century; but Kierkegaard is the Tycho Brahe of our philosophy. He is great as Tycho Brahe was great, but like the astronomer he does not dare, in his blind reverence for authority, to place the center of our system in its sun. In astronomy this sun is a body; in philosophy it is called reason. It seems a tragic fate attached to Denmark that its greatest discoverers should be mistaken about what is central. But just as posterity was not prevented by Tycho Brahe's errors from turning his work to account, just so little does Kierkegaard fall along with the positive element in morality and religion. That element can be separated from his presentation, and infinite treasures will still remain. Those for whom this is a closed book, as it is for Professor R. Nielsen or for Mr. *Gb.*, are fighting only against progress, and striving, though in vain, to keep the true new from breaking its way through. But this new is irresistible; for it bears reason and freedom on its shield.

[98]

A Reply

(1867)

The author of the pamphlet *R. Nielsens Filosofi og den Grundtvigske Anskuelse* has placed in yesterday's *Berlingske Tidende* a rejoinder to my attack on his book, which, without bringing forward anything whatever against the four points I raised, ends with the words that "those who really believe that there is a cause at stake here will not fail to see that he (i.e. I), stung by the goad of self-importance, merely dances a St. Vitus's dance around the great tasks." Such things it is enough to quote; there is no need to answer them.

As regards the accusations and questions that my honored opponent raises besides, it seems to me, however, that I owe an answer, not to him, but to the readers of *Dagbladet*. He reproaches me with having pointed to the French religio-philosophical criticism, "which newspaper readers do not know." I do not see what harm there would be in that, even if it were so; but of course it is not so. In our day newspaper readers, as is well known, do not form a caste of their own; practically all educated people read newspapers. My honored opponent is himself an example. No doubt Mr. Gb. is a most cultivated man (see, e.g., the sample of his style above), but why should *Dagbladet* not be so fortunate as to count among its readers several men just as cultivated, men who among other authors know Renan, whom Mr. Gb., as we know, knows so well?

My opponent next accuses me of having consigned to Hekkenfeldt religious ideas "that have borne mankind up through eighteen centuries." That would undeniably be an ugly trait. But is it really quite certain that I have acted so? Is it certain that the ideas I would have banished have for eighteen centuries *borne human beings up*? (and that, surely, is far less essential than whether they are fit to bear mankind up today). The feuilleton that happened the other day to accompany my article, the fragment on the witch trials of the Middle Ages, which were engendered precisely by the supernatural ideas that I dispute, makes a good contribution to answering this question. In that age, when the supernatural really was alive in human consciousness, the views that nowadays people are content to expose to hatred were punished with the heretic's stake. — A few words I could say in defense of the likeness between religious and political crises I shall spare, since my opponent has so puffed himself up that he *forbids me to speak* of it.

There remains, then, only one point, the question repeated again and again, of whose crushing force people are so convinced: How can I acknowledge Kierkegaard's greatness

and yet be convinced that he was mistaken about what is central? I could answer this question as I have answered it before, with the words that only very dependent people understand by admiring acknowledgment nothing other than simple adherence through thick and thin; but since the question is brought up anew, I add the following brief account of how I have come to this result: I discovered fairly early that Kierkegaard was not infallible. I discovered, e.g., and I suppose many have had the same experience, that Kierkegaard was an adherent of political absolutism in Denmark; that in the political sphere, with a remarkable narrowness in acknowledging the inherited merely because it is inherited, he misunderstood his time and fought against development and progress. I saw that his political prophecies, of which he himself is so proud, did not come true at all. I was thus led to observe that he was an absolutist in the religious sphere as well: that to break with tradition, to desert one's parents', to abandon a father's way of seeing was to him not merely a horror such as is surely felt, though in differing degrees, by everyone who is compelled to look filial piety in the face, and thus not merely a dread that it is man's task to overcome, but a *spiritual* horror of the same kind as the one that nature implants to keep man from committing a crime against nature. I believed, and believe, [100] that he is wrong in this; I hold nothing sacred merely because it has been handed down; for being handed down makes a thing neither rational nor true. I regard it as beyond doubt that on this point one can learn many times more from the religio-philosophical writers of Germany and France than from him.

It is well known that Kierkegaard's works are distinguished by a rare consistency and unity. But it is, if perhaps not generally acknowledged, hardly the less certain for that, that the attempt he made at an advanced stage of his career as an author to demonstrate the inner coherence of all his writings is, on the one hand, very forced, and on the other cannot rule out that these works keep their value in and for themselves, without regard to their place in the system of the writings. Is Kierkegaard on this point anything other than what he would least of all wish to be, and what he hated most of all — a systematizer who laces the free fullness of life into the stays of a preconceived, or rather in part an afterwards-conceived, fundamental thought? He himself is infected by the systematic mania that he combated in his age. But even if it were otherwise, even if everything Kierkegaard has written really did aim, from first to last, at presenting the specifically Christian in the form in which he conceived it, would anyone of another mind therefore be forbidden to take delight in, and make his own, the numerous productions of his that have nothing to do with the paradoxical religiosity? Seen from an alien standpoint, is the essay on Don Juan any less inspired, *In vino veritas* any less brilliant, the essays

on marriage any less captivating, or the presentation of non-Christian religiosity (in *Afsluttende Efterskrift*) any less significant and less instructive? What an absurdity!

But there is no need at all to stop here. In a great many cases where Kierkegaard, in his own opinion, presents the paradoxical (as in *Kærlighedens Gerninger*), this paradoxical element is not contrary to reason at all and can be translated into the language of the human; in other cases, e.g. in *Sygdommen til Døden*, the positive comes in toward the end without being derived. It is impossible, starting from the concept of despair as Kierkegaard at the outset lays it down in purely human terms, to bring despair, and with it sin, to the high point in rationalism's view of the Christian. There is, then, much in [101] this that a worshipper of reason can make his own, and much else that he will cut away as an excrescence.

Such a separation of what one regards as the lasting in Kierkegaard from what one considers the transient is something that simply cannot be avoided at all. If one will have no such separation, then let one take the consequences, and with Kierkegaard in his last public stand reject the whole life of the church and the whole life of human society, marriage, etc., which is surely the last thing the half-Grundtvigians would want. Let no one insist that he is at one with Kierkegaard on what is central when he himself will at any price break off the finest and sharpest point in which his whole endeavor culminates. All or nothing, that cry so popular in our day, is a watchword that, where acknowledgment is in question, signifies nothing other than an attempt on the life of all criticism.

Mr. 99 of "Fædrelandet" (Bjørnstjerne Bjørnson)

[102]

(1867)

The honorable gentleman who has come out against me in *Fædrelandet* under the mark 99 possesses, among other engaging qualities, an uncommon effrontery. It sounds incredible, but it is true, that Mr. 99 has not even read for himself the book over which he has taken up arms. The quotations he prints from this book are nowhere to be found in the work; what he puts forward as the book's words are *sentences of mine*. Likewise: what he quotes from *Fædrelandet* is not the paper's words but *mine*. He quotes me alternately in small type (as proof of how presumptuous I am) and in large type (in the belief that he is setting my opponents' words against mine); it seems to me that this little fact is in and of itself enough to show what kind of opponent he is.

Like his kindred spirit in *Berlingske Tidende*, 99 wisely skips over all the main points and throws himself upon the quite inessential comparison I made. I said: it is not always the most violent crisis that brings about the best and truest result; thus, e.g., in the middle of this century we Danes in the political sphere, and the French in the religio-philosophical, have taken a great step forward without violent crises, and conversely the political revolutions in France and the theologico-philosophical movements in Denmark have not led directly to freedom. This was the comparison, and it seems to me that it [103] is clear. One can of course ride it to death, as one can any comparison; but one has no right to want it stretched further than I have stretched it; for otherwise it is truly easy enough to make it limp: "In the French Revolution blood was shed, in our theological disputes none was shed, therefore etc."; "Napoleon III put an end to the last revolution, our science has no Napoleon III, therefore etc." That our political movement presupposes the French one, while the French know nothing of Kierkegaard — German literature they know very well — is quite irrelevant to the comparison; but for the rest, this conception of the reason for the relation I mentioned is as shallow as it could possibly be. The reason is that the Romance and the Gotho-Germanic stocks have quite different capacities and tasks; the Romance stock, represented by the French, conceives and develops morality socially, the Gotho-Germanic stock conceives and develops it personally. The former always makes the beginning socially; from the latter the reforms proceed in the personal sphere; and each appropriates the results of the other's efforts. In the direction in which each of the stocks is least developed, it receives the results from the other without much struggle, whereas the more developed one may fight itself so weary that for a time it lies

exhausted and is unable to draw the consequences it has itself prepared. Mr. 99 stamps this view as “nonsense” and the comparison as an “unseemly blunder”. There can be so great a gulf between the development of two people that the words of the one, however clear and well-founded they may be, must necessarily look meaningless to the other.

If any proof were needed of my remark that here people will not refute but declaim, my opponents have now supplied it; for with what have they answered me, if not with insults, with high-handed pronouncements and with appeals to national feeling? The one *forbids* me to call Kierkegaard the Tycho Brahe of our philosophy — something, however, in which I intend to persist, with or without his permission. The other would have me denied all use of pen and ink whatever, at least in the daily papers. O noble man! Yes indeed, it would be splendid if one could get rid of the restless spirits in this way and sit so snug in one’s own little soap-cellar! Certainly it is easier to gag than [104] to refute; but alas, those golden days of the Middle Ages, when such things went so smoothly and so easily — they are over, those feast-days¹⁾.

But I come to the most wounding attack that has been directed at me. It is this: that “the man who can feel and speak” as I do “has no view in common with other Danes, has no Danish consciousness”. My view is — not illogical, but — *un-Danish*. What is it, then, that I have said? That Kierkegaard, in my conviction, went wrong in what is central, i.e. in what he took to be central, the doctrine of the paradox — not, of course, in what I take to be central in his writings, their purely human content. Is it a crime against one’s fatherland to say this? Has this pronounced “the death sentence on Danish culture”? Have we perhaps acquired a philosophical authority into the bargain, alongside the religious ones? Kierkegaard must be right. Why? Because he is Danish. And Martensen, his opponent? Right, because he is Danish. And Grundtvig, his antipode? Right, because he is Danish. And Tycho Brahe against Copernicus? Right, because he is Danish. Yes, it is well enough known that this last Grundtvigian inference has already been drawn, with sublime contempt for all sound reason. Down with him who dares to say that “Danish culture” is not in every respect the best, soundest, truest on earth!

“Will *Dagbladet* henceforth keep contributors,” exclaims Mr. 99 — the expression “keep” is itself telling — contributors “who repeatedly encourage the youth of Denmark to come and see with their own eyes, if they do not wish to be called intellectually bound

¹⁾An interesting parallel, as regards the kinship between the astronomical relocation of the center and the philosophical relocation of it to revelation, is afforded by the following quotation: “*Pascal* somewhere corrected a sentence of his own, took it back and recast it, in order to make the sun turn around the earth and not the earth around the sun. This great spirit, which on this point still harbored a remnant of superstition, shrank back from the truth of Copernicus.”

Sainte-Beuve: *Causeries du lundi* III S. 254.

to the soil”? Yes, is it not dreadful to urge the Danish youth to see with their own eyes? No, let us stay in the rut we are in now, let us all together become Nittengryns and Ninety-Niners; for what does it not say in the Fox’s *Morals* in Holberg, Art. 17 and Art. 18: “*Scruple* not in religion; but hold thee blindly to the reigning faith so long as it is on [105] the throne, for it is most seemly and safest to follow the fashion, in this as in dress. — Trouble thee not to search out the truth; but believe what thou art bidden to believe; for the first is both dangerous and troublesome, the second, on the other hand, safe and comfortable; yea, it often paves the way to *canonization*”.

[106]

*Heegaard: Professor R. Nielsens Lære om
Tro og Viden*

[Professor R. Nielsen's Doctrine of Faith and Knowledge]

(1867)

There has just appeared *Professor R. Nielsens Lære om Tro og Viden*, a critical treatise by Dr. P. S. V. Heegaard. It makes no secret of what it bears on its shield; for on the very cover it carries the motto: "A philosophy that is in open contradiction with sound understanding is false." The book is a literary curiosity, not so much for its content — for part of what it presents has been said before — as for the surprise it occasions, to see *this* view expressed from *this* quarter; a pleasant surprise, to be sure, but nonetheless, as Nonpareil says in *Recensenten og Dyret*: la surprise surprenante des surpris.

For the author, as is well known, was one of Professor Nielsen's most faithful; he has been the Professor's pupil, adherent and secretary, and now — alas, how changed! Where now is the time when Dr. Heegaard, as the highly trusted disciple, lay on the Master's breast and rose only to chastise with severity the *rash* attempt of an *immature* youth to tear down a certain solidly founded doctrine? Yes, where are the snows of yesteryear? And yet Dr. Heegaard was right then. Was it not perhaps *precipitate*? Why should the young people hurry so, why come two whole years too early? Could they not easily have waited a little and taken Dr. Heegaard along? After all, he only wanted a little trip [107] abroad first (see the last page of the book). And was it not an *immature* undertaking to sound the attack before the crack troops had arrived, to charge without waiting for so brave and valuable a reinforcement? Yes indeed: for how did it go? Alas, miserably; the ranks wavered, the attackers were done for; then, at the decisive moment, Dr. Heegaard arrives like Desaix at Marengo. Straight out of Professor Nielsen's own camp he breaks forth all at once, with flying colors and full band, leaving behind nothing but a trumpet, which, it is said, is now vacant. He hastens over to the opposing side, he falls upon the Professor's flank; it is in deadly earnest, and one comes over quite solemn at such a spectacle. Happily, a little jest and fun mingles with the solemnity of the procession and the horrors of war.

For example: what has offended him and provoked him to deliver his bloody critique, says the author, is the claim that Professor Nielsen, as a mind of the first rank, has brought about a great philosophical breakthrough. This is of course a jest; for as is well

known it is the author himself who earliest and most eagerly set this claim down in writing. Further: it is most unfortunate, Dr. Heegaard thinks, that Professor Nielsen, who began as a “pure Hegelian”, later became Hegel’s decided opponent. Another jest — namely, a jesting illustration of the proverb: One should not speak of rope etc. Finally: consider *Grundideernes Logik*, says the author; the best thing would be for Professor Nielsen, who is after all unable to complete the building, to leave it standing unfinished at once, as an “interesting ruin”, and so as a kind of Marble Church. “Marble Church yourself,” answers Professor Nielsen, calmly pointing to the first part of the far-famed *Indledning til den rationelle Etik*. Now is this not a merry situation?

But joking aside, it is clear enough that precisely the mixed, half pathetic, half comic position in which Dr. Heegaard finds himself as the author of this book greatly increases the weight of his critical pronouncement. With what irresistible power must the truth not have shown itself to him, since he has made so great a sacrifice to it! His critique accordingly bears witness first and foremost to a truth-loving mind, resolved no longer to let itself be dazzled, not to be content with flourishes or riddles, to lay bare the web of subtleties and fallacies on which Professor Nielsen’s so-called philosophy of religion rests. The critique is as able as it is serious, and as sharp as it is dogged and merciless. [108] It tears apart the flimsy cobweb of the brain in which so many weak souls have been caught like flies, and it is, as a whole, so decisive and definite that it would now, after all, seem bound to become clear even to the slowest head that Professor Nielsen has lost the battle and that his doctrine has gone the way of all flesh.

What is new in Dr. Heegaard’s treatment of the question is chiefly this: that instead of showing how Professor Nielsen’s doctrine conflicts with the truth in and for itself, he proves it by a detour, through a demonstration of how Nielsen, in every branch of his science, comes into contradiction *with himself* through his reason-defying conception of the relation between faith and knowledge. For a critique of this nature Dr. Heegaard, with his special qualifications, with his exhaustive knowledge of Professor Nielsen’s entire system, was admirably equipped, and it leaves very little to be desired. Here and there, to be sure, there is some unclarity (as, e.g., in the conception of the Mystery as a category), and now and then a somewhat perverse interpretation of the opponent’s words (as where the Mystery is equated with the Meaning); but these small defects vanish beside the thoroughness and sharpness that otherwise distinguish the argument line by line.

The book is *purely* critical; it barely so much as hints at a standpoint of its own; the author seems to have only just come out of the Nielsenian school without yet having

gained a foothold himself. It cannot be denied that this circumstance gives the book and its style something dry and coldly cerebral; there is in the author's personality no primitiveness, none of that native originality which, with the sureness of instinct or of genius, seizes what presents itself to it as truth; as a writer he seems to lack the best thing of all: the productive gift which, after the habit of barren natures, he would deny to *the age*.

That is why it surprises us that he does not value this capacity more highly in his former teacher. For much can be said against Professor Nielsen, and much ought to be said against him: he has entangled himself in a religio-philosophical maze, and as a thinker he is no systematician at all; but he has the luxuriantly fertile mind, the eye of genius, the rare originality, which are just as essential capacities in a thinker as the [109] strictly scientific cultivation of thought and a sharp and reliable understanding. One misses in Dr. Heegaard's book a proper acknowledgment of this. The gratitude which undoubtedly dwells in the author's mind toward his so highly gifted teacher could have found fuller expression; it ought not to have been squeezed into a brief declaration, but ought to have pervaded the whole development and made impossible the irritated tone in which his critique speaks more than once.
